S.M.A.K.R. Framework for Understanding Arguments

1. Skeleton (S)

- **Question:** How is the stimulus structured, or what are the author’s premise and conclusion?
- **Explanation:** Identifying the argument core is crucial. This means finding the premises (the reasons or evidence provided) and the Main conclusion (the main point the author is trying to make) and Intermediate conclusion if applicable . Understanding this helps us see the framework of the argument.

2. Method (M)

- **Question:** What kind of argumentative technique, or type of logic, do they use to go from premise to conclusion?
- **Explanation:** Recognizing the method or technique the author uses to link premises to the conclusion helps us understand the flow of the argument. Techniques might include causal reasoning, analogy, generalization, or conditional logic (if-then statements). For example, in conditional logic, identify the sufficient condition (if part) and the necessary condition (then part), and determine if the argument correctly uses the contrapositive (if not then not).

3. Assumption (A)

- **Question:** Are there any gaps or logical leaps in the author’s reasoning, and does the author make any assumptions in their argument?
- **Explanation:** Identifying assumptions and gaps is vital. Assumptions are unstated premises that the argument depends on. Gaps are places where the reasoning might not fully connect.

4. Keyword Extraction (K)

- **Question:** Are there keywords (nouns, verbs, adjectives/adverbs) in answer choices that seem unclear or suspicious?
- **Explanation:** Keywords help in identifying important parts of the argument and in spotting the same or similar ideas in the answer choices. They can also highlight shifts in meaning or emphasis.

5. Ranking Answer Choices (R)

- **Question:** If there are no seemingly perfect answer choices, how would you rank them?
- **Explanation:** When faced with tricky questions, ranking the answer choices based on how well they align with the argument's structure, method, assumptions, and keywords helps in narrowing down the best possible choice.

Using this S.M.A.K.R. framework ensures a comprehensive approach to analyzing and understanding arguments, making it easier to tackle challenging Logical Reasoning questions on the LSAT. ```